

Choose wisely

Before you purchase a product, try and find out about available servicing options. Also, do not forget to get a bill for your purchase

For advice and information on
consumer rights, visit
consumermate.com

Dear Sir,

Thank you for your article on Consumer Protection in the December issue of Digit. I purchased an N72 Nokia cellphone on April 08, 2009. I experienced faults such as blank display on 11-05-2009, but they returned the phone to me mentioning the fault as boot failure and saying it's irreparable. The details are as follows:

Service job sheet number: 31346550/090511/2

(May 11, 2009)

IMEI Number: 356295014025833

Product Code: 0531541

Job Warranty: No

Model Name: N72

Service Invoice: 4217 (May 30, 2009)

Remarks: Boot failure

Please guide me for further action.

Regards,

Srirengam V

Ariyalur

Attached:

Service Job sheet

Service invoice

We all have a right to be safe. However, taking necessary precautions is our duty as a consumer. In the same light, educating us on safe practices lies with the product manufacturer. Avoid using a product in unhealthy or destructive environments by knowing its operating specifications. Even if you get the best coverage near your local petrol pump, it may still not be the best place to talk. Your cellphone's user manual also specifies the same and is laced with advisories.

Be aware of your rights and duties as a consumer. Rights to prevent abuse and being taken for a ride. At the same, it is our duty to stay safe. Most warranties and guarantees absolve companies from any liability arising out of alteration to the product from the user's end. If you have opened your PMP yourself in a fit of rage, the company is not liable to you anymore to ensure a satisfactory audio experience.

India's consumer forums are in place too, but one aspect where we lack is general awareness. There are Consumer Redressal Forums in the country to address our concerns surrounding consumer rights. We'd agree to the fact – laws are futile without adequate policing. However, what use is effective policing when there's a lack of general public awareness?

Hundreds of you have written to us complaining on different companies. We followed up on one such letter from Srirengam who is based in Ariyalur, Chennai. We spoke to Srirengam, who seemed to have lost hope in being helped out with his faulty phone. Around a year after buying the phone, it started blanking out.

In May 2009, Srirengam sent it to the Nokia service personnel. However they returned it to him saying the problem cannot be rectified. We forwarded this letter to Nokia. We will continue our follow-up. Meanwhile, if any of you have similar experiences, please do let us know. Drop in an email at servicewatch@thinkdigit.com and we'll take up your issue with the concerned authorities. **d**

Wake up, be wise

We've heard a lot about consumer rights all through the ages. It's time to wake up and stand up for yourself!

Nash David

servicewatch@thinkdigit.com

Consumer is king. We hear such promising phrases practically everywhere we move. Way back in 1962, US President John F. Kennedy equipped Americans with six powerful rights – the right to be safe, choose freely, be heard, stay informed, be educated, and the right to service.

Welcome to democracy, a world where citizens have freedom, liberty and equality in all choices they make. This is inherent, and more so in a free world. Be it batteries exploding or laptops overheating, the least we

expect is corrective surgery to retain our sanity. Be it America, or the world's largest democracy – India – an individual can never be denied his/her rights. What we need, is increased awareness. In fact, that's exactly the aim of those advertisements on television that are “issued in public interest” by the Government of India. We should be watching diligently rather than mocking them.

These advertisements tell us to be wise, watchful and look for crucial information on the product label such as warranty details. We should do our part rather than scoff at something we consider too lame. Even insisting on a bill is a basic consumer right.